

Balaji Ramakrishnan

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Category Head with 8+ years of experience owning end-to-end category P&L across D2C, marketplaces, and global brands. Proven track record of scaling revenue, improving inventory efficiency, and driving margin-led growth through data-driven buying, assortment strategy, and sourcing optimization. Experienced in leading teams, managing large SKU portfolios, and partnering cross-functionally to deliver speed, scale, and profitability.

EDUCATION

National Institute of Fashion Technology, Chennai, India
Bachelor of Fashion Technology, Apparel Production

(2012-2016)

EXPERIENCE

Buying & Category Manager, Bewakoof, India

(11/2024-Present)

Led buying and merchandising for the Men's category across D2C, marketplaces, and offline channels; managed and mentored a 2-member team.

- Drove 43% revenue growth in men's (₹106.81 Cr → ₹152.96 Cr) while achieving 3.7x inventory turns.
- Improved unit economics: +5% Gross Margin, +2% ASP, +11% RPTI, alongside -8% COGS and -1% NTG.
- Optimized assortment through gap analysis, demand forecasting, hero SKU development, and standardization of fabrics and fits.
- Exceeded CY25 AOP by 5% and delivered 70% sell-through.
- Reduced Weeks of Cover (WOC) from 16 to 14 weeks and lowered inventory age by 18%.
- Increased in-stock availability of top SKUs by 32%, driving a 30% uplift in sales contribution.
- Built and automated sales & merchandising dashboards using Python, integrating multi-platform data for real-time decision-making.
- Oversaw an assortment of 1,700 SKUs per season, with 70% fashion / 30% bestseller mix across D2C and marketplaces.

Associate Merchandising Manager, Myntra, India

(12/2021-11/2024)

Managing the merchandising charter for international license brands in Myntra – Nautica and FC/FCUK across offline and online channels.

- Scaled Nautica revenue from ₹52.3 Cr (CY21) to ₹103.9 Cr (CY22), driving 99% YoY growth and 129% AOP achievement.
- Delivered 91% volume growth in CY22 (456,846 pcs) through repeat programs and option expansion.
- Optimized repeat styles contributing 30% incremental revenue with +3% GM vs fashion styles.
- Improved apparel BM by 1% (79% → 80%) despite 30%+ cotton cost inflation.
- Achieved 10% cost reduction from AW22 to SS23, saving ₹82.4L; expanded option count from 617 to 1,181.

Merchandiser, C&A International Ltd., India

(10/2017-12/2021)

Managed the entire merchandising and sourcing for all brands under men's and accessories division right from range planning until store inwards with 6 core and 4 non-core suppliers spread across India and Sri Lanka.

- Led the Test–Repeat program, reducing total lead time from 100–120 days to 30–40 days through raw material analysis and pre-booking.
- Co-developed a basic shirt at \$3.7 FOB using BCI cotton, delivering sustainability targets while achieving ~97% margin.
- Reduced lead time of a seasonal repeat program by 39% by re-engineering the critical path and improving supplier coordination.
- Drove a sustainability initiative converting 97% of men's conventional cotton styles sourced from India and Sri Lanka to bio-cotton.
- Led costing deep-dives and vendor negotiations, securing margins in the 70–95% range across key programs.
- Strategically planned and sourced styles by aligning product complexity with optimal suppliers, delivering ~\$40K annual cost savings.
- Partnered with suppliers and cross-functional teams to consistently achieve 95%+ on-time delivery (OTD).
- Collaborated closely with design teams to co-develop seasonal collections, maximizing mark-up and commercial viability.

Assistant Merchandiser, Lenny Fashions, Bangladesh

(8/2016-9/2017)

Handled Macy's end-to-end merchandising operations right from product development till the execution of export orders while completely overseeing the development, sourcing, production, quality and distribution of merchandise from factory to the finished product.

- Implemented garment construction changes and reutilized excess inventory to reduce fabric consumption for JC Penney's Summer 2017 collection, resulting in profit increase of \$329,668
- Analyzed the product in detail, sourced and developed the fabrics and trims required onboarding new suppliers to improve quality and lead time
- Led root-cause analysis on rejected garments and implemented corrective actions with production teams, reducing defect rate from 15% to 9%.

Intern, Decathlon, India

(1/2016-4/2016)

- Developed an intrinsic model to gauge the underlying reasons for low employee performance and increase employee engagement and efficiency

Leadership & Affiliations

- Awarded Extraordinary Student Service award for the batch of 2012-2016
- President of Cultural Club at NIFT, 2014. Managed the club's budget from 2013-2015
- National Cadet Corps (India) - Company Sergeant Manager rank